

■ SOUTHERN LATITUDES

Boötes and Hercules are on either side of due north. The figures of the huntsman and hero are found by locating the bright stars Arcturus and Vega, which is just peeking above the northeastern horizon. On the left, Boötes is head down



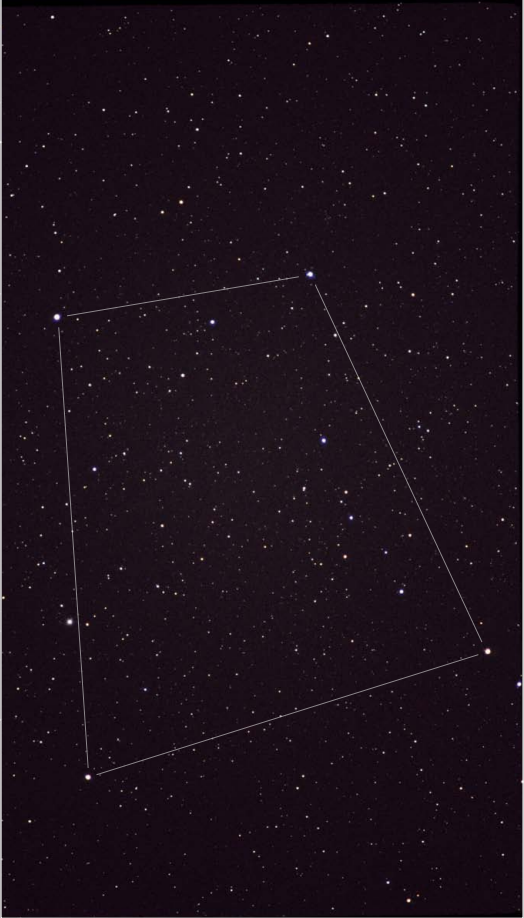
and feet high; at right, Hercules is head high and feet down, with an arm outstretched above Vega. His lower body is represented by four linked stars known as the Keystone. The star cluster M13 lies on a line linking two of the stars. Aquila and its bright star Altair are now in the northeast.

Overhead, the distinctive shape of Scorpius with its curving tail is clearly seen. Its heart is marked by Antares, a red supergiant whose brightness varies between magnitudes 0.9 and 1.2 over a four- to five-year period. Two open-star clusters, M6 and M7, are found near the stinger in the scorpion's tail. Both are visible to the naked eye.

Scorpius and its neighbor Sagittarius lie in the Milky Way and in the direction of the center of our galaxy. From Sagittarius and Scorpius, the milky path of light flows to the southwest, taking in the constellations Centaurus and Crux along the way. The globular cluster Omega (ω) Centauri is well placed, as are the dark Coalsack nebula and the Jewel Box (NGC 4755) open cluster, both in Crux.

Butterfly Cluster

The Butterfly Cluster (M6) is an open cluster in Scorpius. It is about 2,000 light-years away and about 12 light-years across. Its brightest star is an orange giant whose light varies over time. The star cluster is found near the stinger of the scorpion's tail.



The Keystone in Hercules

The four stars that form the lower body of Hercules are known as the Keystone. The globular cluster M13 is bisected by a line joining two of the stars (seen here at left). The cluster can be seen from both northern and southern latitudes.

